

Psalms 127

Except the Lord Build the House

Except the Lord build the house, they labour in vain that build it
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Except the LORD build the house, they labour in vain that build it: except the LORD keep the city, the watchman waketh but in vain.*
- 2 *It is vain for you to rise up early, to sit up late, to eat the bread of sorrows: for so he giveth his beloved sleep.*
- 3 *Lo, children are an heritage of the LORD: and the fruit of the womb is his reward.*
- 4 *As arrows are in the hand of a mighty man; so are children of the youth.*
- 5 *Happy is the man that hath his quiver full of them: they shall not be ashamed, but they shall speak with the enemies in the gate.*

2 • CONTEXT

Attributed to Solomon, Psalm 127 pairs two seemingly separate topics—building projects and family life—under a single governing principle: without the Lord's involvement, human effort and anxious striving accomplish nothing lasting, while what He provides comes without the frantic labor people assume is necessary. Henry reads the psalm as a correction to workaholic anxiety specifically, noting how directly it links restless overwork with a lack of trust, then pivots to children as a concrete picture of blessing that is received rather than manufactured.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with a double illustration of futility apart from God: except the Lord build the house, builders labor in vain; except the Lord keep the city, a watchman's vigilance is useless. Anxious effort is named specifically—rising early, staying up late, eating the bread of sorrows—all deemed vain, since God gives sleep, and by implication provision, to those He loves without requiring that frantic striving.

Verse 3-5

Attention turns to children, described as a heritage and reward from the Lord rather than achievements to be engineered. They are compared to arrows in the hand of a mighty warrior, useful and purposeful; the one whose quiver is full of them is called happy, secure rather than ashamed when facing opposition at the city gate.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Effort disconnected from trust in God produces only exhausting futility—rising early, staying late, laboring anxiously for outcomes that ultimately depend on His blessing rather than human striving alone. Children, offered as this psalm's primary example, illustrate that some of life's most significant blessings are received as gifts rather than manufactured through sheer effort.

Application for life today.

Examine your own patterns of overwork—rising early, staying up late, driven by anxiety rather than trust—and consider what this psalm's warning against 'vain' labor (v. 2) specifically challenges in your schedule. If you have children or those under your care, let verses 3–5 reshape how you view them: as a received heritage rather than a project to be perfected through your own effort alone. Practice actually resting, as verse 2 pictures—trusting God enough to receive sleep and provision rather than treating exhaustion as evidence of faithfulness.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where does your own pattern of overwork—rising early, staying up late, driven by anxiety—match the 'vain' labor this psalm warns against (v. 2)?

2. If you have children or people under your care, how does verse 3's description of them as a 'heritage' from the Lord, rather than your own achievement, change how you view your role?

3. What would it look like to actually practice the rest verse 2 pictures—trusting God enough to receive provision rather than treating constant exhaustion as proof of faithfulness?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).